INTERVIEW PREPARATION HANDBOOK

DevOps AWS

Zemoso Labs · Bangalore / Pune

101 questions

15 topic areas

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Saroj Kumar Nayak

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Role & Positioning

FRAMING THE FIT

Why are you a strong fit for this DevOps AWS role given your certifications are Azure-focused (AZ-104, SC-300, SC-100)?

q001

I'd frame it as breadth, not a mismatch. My day-to-day hands-on experience — 6+ years — has been on AWS: EC2, IAM, EKS, CloudFormation-style provisioning, the works. The Azure certifications came from client engagements that needed that stack, particularly the AZ-104 for infrastructure administration and SC-300/SC-100 for identity and security architecture. What that combination actually gives me is a security- and identity-first mental model — SC-300 forces you to think in terms of least-privilege, conditional access, and identity lifecycle, and that maps directly onto how I approach AWS IAM: roles over long-lived keys, scoped policies, and permission boundaries. So rather than 'I know Azure, not AWS,' the honest and accurate framing is 'I've built deep AWS operational experience and layered formal identity/security architecture training from Azure on top of it — and that security lens travels across clouds.'

The JD says 5+ years overall IT/DevOps with 3+ years specifically on AWS, and 7+ preferred for senior level. How do you position your 14+ years?

q002

I'd walk through it as depth plus range rather than just a bigger number. Of my 14+ years, a large chunk has been hands-on AWS work — provisioning, IAM, EKS, CI/CD, troubleshooting production incidents — well past their 3-year bar and comfortably past the 7-year senior preference. The remaining years weren't idle either; they were spent in adjacent disciplines — platform support, Windows and Linux administration, application build tooling — that built the systems-comprehension muscle this JD explicitly asks for under 'Core Traits.' I'd say something like: 'the extra years aren't padding, they're where I built the habit of reading unfamiliar infrastructure and reasoning about it from first principles, which is exactly what your Core Traits section is testing for.'

Zemoso Labs works across multiple client engagements as a product-engineering studio. How do you handle supporting multiple teams or clients at once?

q003

This is where my Unique Vacations/Sandals Resorts and Terawe/Microsoft-client engagements are directly relevant — both were consulting-style setups where I wasn't the sole owner of one internal product, I was supporting an external client's infrastructure against their priorities and SLAs. The discipline that works is: treat each engagement's runbooks, on-call expectations, and change-approval process as first-class and distinct — don't let habits from one client leak into another's environment by muscle memory. Practically that means keeping engagement-specific documentation and IaC state cleanly separated (separate backends, separate IAM boundaries, separate context in my head before I touch anything), and being explicit in stand-ups about which client's work is currently in flight so nothing gets context-switched sloppily. It's less about heroic multitasking and more about disciplined isolation between engagements.

The JD's 'Documentation-First Mindset' bullet explicitly says 'maintains a low dependency on AI tools like Copilot for core troubleshooting.' How do you actually feel about that requirement? q004

I'd answer this honestly rather than performatively agreeing, because I think that's what they're actually testing for. My position: AI tools are fine for scaffolding — generating a first-draft Terraform module, explaining an unfamiliar error message, or drafting a runbook — but they're the wrong tool for live production troubleshooting, and here's the concrete reason why: an AI assistant pattern-matches against training data, it doesn't have access to your actual CloudWatch logs, your actual `kubectl describe` output, or your actual VPC flow logs in that moment. When something's actually broken at 2 AM, the fastest and most reliable path is reading the real logs, correlating timestamps, and building a mental model of what changed — which is exactly the AWS-docs-first, read-the-actual-output habit I built over 14 years before Copilot-style tools existed. So I'd tell them: I use AI tools to go faster on the boilerplate, and I deliberately don't lean on them when I'm debugging something that's actually down, because that's when you need ground truth, not a plausible-sounding guess.

This JD leans heavily on AWS CloudFormation as the primary IaC tool, with Terraform as secondary — most of your recent project depth has been Terraform-heavy. How do you address that gap honestly? q005

I'd be upfront rather than overstate it: my deepest hands-on repetition is with Terraform — state management, module design, the workspace/backend patterns. CloudFormation I've used, but not at the same daily-driver depth. What I'd emphasize is that the concepts transfer almost completely — declarative resource definitions, drift detection, dependency graphs, rollback-on-failure semantics — the syntax and state model differ (YAML/JSON templates and stacks vs. HCL and a separate state file) but the mental model of 'infrastructure as reviewable, versioned code' is identical. I'd say directly: 'I can be productive in CloudFormation from day one because the underlying discipline is the same one I've applied in Terraform for years — I'll just need a short ramp-up on CloudFormation-specific syntax like intrinsic functions and nested stacks, which given the JD's own emphasis on self-learning autonomy and documentation-first habits, is exactly the kind of ramp-up I'm built for.' Gap-acknowledging beats bluffing here.

What would your first 30 days look like in this role? q006

Week one is almost entirely absorption, not action: read every existing CloudFormation template and Terraform module to understand what's actually deployed versus what the docs claim is deployed — those two things drift, and catching that drift early avoids embarrassing mistakes later. I'd map the account/VPC topology, the EKS cluster layout, and who owns what across the 'diverse infrastructure landscape' the JD mentions, including where the Windows hosts sit and how they're managed differently from the Linux fleet. Weeks two and three, I'd start taking small, reviewed changes — a Helm chart tweak, a CI pipeline fix — to build trust and calibrate the team's review culture before touching anything IAM- or network-related. By day 30 I'd want to have shadowed at least one production incident end-to-end and to have a written list of the top three things I don't yet understand about the environment, because in a role this autonomy-heavy, knowing what you don't know is the actual deliverable of month one.

AWS Core & Infrastructure

PROVISIONING & ARCHITECTURE

How do you approach designing and provisioning cloud infrastructure on AWS for a new service from scratch? q007

I start from the workload's actual requirements, not a template: expected traffic pattern, data sensitivity, latency needs, and compliance constraints, because those drive the VPC design before anything else. I'd lay out a multi-AZ VPC with public subnets only for load balancers/NAT gateways and everything else private, size subnets with real headroom using CIDR math rather than guessing, and decide compute (EKS vs. ECS vs. EC2 Auto Scaling) based on the team's operational maturity with containers rather than defaulting to Kubernetes because it's fashionable. Everything gets written as IaC from the first resource — no console click-ops that later needs to be reverse-engineered into a template — and I bake in IAM least-privilege, encryption at rest/in transit, and CloudWatch/Grafana observability as part of the initial design, not an afterthought bolted on before a compliance audit.

Walk me through how you'd design highly available infrastructure on AWS. q008

High availability starts with spreading everything that can fail across at least two, ideally three, Availability Zones — EC2/EKS nodes, RDS/Aurora with Multi-AZ enabled, and NAT gateways per AZ rather than one shared NAT gateway, which is a classic single point of failure people miss. Load balancers (ALB/NLB) sit in front with health checks tuned aggressively enough to pull a bad instance out fast but not so aggressively they flap on transient blips. For data, Aurora's storage layer is already replicated across AZs so failover is a promotion of a replica rather than a data-copy event, typically under 30 seconds. I'd also design for AZ-level and region-level failure separately — Multi-AZ handles the former, but if the JD's infra includes anything regulatory or business-critical, I'd have a documented (even if not fully automated) cross-region DR runbook, because 'highly available' and 'disaster recoverable' are different guarantees that people conflate.

What's your process for managing a 'diverse infrastructure landscape including data pipelines and Windows hosts,' as this JD phrases it? q009

The core discipline is not treating everything as if it were a stateless Linux container, because it isn't. For data pipelines, I care about idempotency and checkpointing — can a failed pipeline run be safely retried without double-processing data — and I'd want CloudWatch alarms on pipeline-specific metrics like records-processed or lag, not just generic CPU/memory. Windows hosts need a genuinely different toolchain: PowerShell DSC or SSM State Manager instead of a shell-script cron job, Windows Event Log instead of syslog for troubleshooting, and patching cadence via Systems Manager Patch Manager with a maintenance window strategy that respects Windows' reboot-heavy patching model. The mistake I actively avoid is assuming Linux operational patterns — like assuming a service restart is cheap, or that logs live in `/var/log` — will just work on the Windows side; I keep separate runbooks per platform rather than a single generic one that quietly fails for half the fleet.

How do you manage AWS costs while keeping infrastructure secure and reliable? q010

I treat cost as a design input alongside security and reliability, not a separate FinOps exercise done after the fact. Concretely: right-sizing instances against actual CloudWatch utilization data rather than the size someone guessed at launch, Reserved Instances or Savings Plans for steady-state baseline load with On-Demand or Spot for bursty/batch workloads, S3 lifecycle policies moving cold data to Glacier automatically, and tagging everything by cost center/environment from day one so cost allocation reports are actually usable instead of a forensic exercise later. On the security side, cost-cutting shouldn't mean cutting corners — for example, I wouldn't disable CloudTrail or reduce log retention to save money, since that trades a small, predictable saving for a much larger risk if there's ever an incident that needs investigation.

What's your experience with AWS Organizations and multi-account strategy? q011

The pattern I follow is Landing Zone thinking even if the environment predates AWS Control Tower: a dedicated management/root account that does nothing but billing and organizational policy, a shared services account for things like a central CI/CD runner fleet or a shared Route 53 hosted zone, and separate accounts per environment — dev, staging, prod — rather than separating environments by VPC inside one account. That account-level boundary is what actually enforces blast-radius containment: an IAM misconfiguration in dev can't touch prod resources because there's no network or IAM path between the accounts at all, versus VPC-level separation which still shares the account's IAM trust boundary. Service Control Policies at the OU level then enforce guardrails — like blocking region usage outside approved regions, or preventing root user API calls — that apply organization-wide regardless of what any individual account's IAM policies say.

How do you handle secrets management on AWS — for example, database credentials used by an application running on EKS? q012

Secrets Manager is my default over Parameter Store for anything that's an actual credential, because it supports automatic rotation with a Lambda rotation function, and for RDS/Aurora that rotation is essentially built-in. On EKS specifically, I'd use the AWS Secrets and Configuration Provider (ASCP) for the Secrets Store CSI Driver so secrets are mounted as files into the pod at runtime rather than baked into environment variables or, worse, committed to a Helm values file — env vars are visible via `kubectl describe pod` and process listings, which is a real leak vector people underestimate. IAM Roles for Service Accounts (IRSA) scopes exactly which pod's service account can read exactly which secret, so even a compromised pod can't enumerate every secret in the account. I'd also make sure secret access shows up in CloudTrail so an unexpected read is something we'd actually notice.

IaC — CloudFormation & Terraform

CLOUDFORMATION FUNDAMENTALS

☐ Walk me through the core building blocks of a CloudFormation template.

q013

A template is JSON or YAML with a handful of top-level sections. `Parameters` are the inputs you pass in at stack-creation time — environment name, instance type, that kind of thing. `Resources` is the mandatory section: every AWS resource you're declaring, each with a logical ID, a `Type` like `AWS::EC2::Instance`, and `Properties`. `Outputs` exposes values — like a VPC ID or a load balancer DNS name — for other stacks or for `aws cloudformation describe-stacks` to consume. `Mappings` is a static lookup table, commonly used for region-to-AMI-ID mapping. `Conditions` let you conditionally create resources — for example, only create a NAT Gateway if the environment is prod. And intrinsic functions — `!Ref`, `!GetAtt`, `!Sub`, `!Join` — are how you wire resources together and interpolate values, playing roughly the same role that Terraform's implicit resource-reference syntax and `${}` interpolation play.

A minimal example tying those together — an S3 bucket whose name is parameterized and whose ARN is exposed as an output for another stack to consume:

```
Parameters:
  EnvironmentName:
    Type: String

Resources:
  AppBucket:
    Type: AWS::S3::Bucket
    Properties:
      BucketName: !Sub "app-artifacts-${EnvironmentName}"

Outputs:
  BucketArn:
    Value: !GetAtt AppBucket.Arn
    Export:
      Name: !Sub "${EnvironmentName}-BucketArn"
```

That `Export` / `Fn::ImportValue` pairing is CloudFormation's version of Terraform's remote state data source — it's how one stack shares a value with another without them being directly coupled.

☐ What are nested stacks in CloudFormation, and why would you use them?

q014

A nested stack is a CloudFormation stack that's itself declared as a resource — `AWS::CloudFormation::Stack` — inside a parent template, pointing at a separate template file (usually in S3). The main reason to use them is the same reason you'd modularize Terraform into reusable modules: breaking a large, unwieldy template into logical, independently-testable units — say, a network stack, an IAM stack, and an application stack — that a parent template composes together, passing outputs from one as parameters into the next. The trade-off versus a single flat template is added complexity in managing the S3-hosted child templates and slightly more painful debugging, since a failure can originate several stack-levels deep, so I only reach for nested stacks once a template genuinely gets too large to reason about as one file — not as a default starting pattern.

How does CloudFormation drift detection work, and when have you used it?

q015

Drift detection compares the current actual state of your deployed resources against what the template declares, resource by resource, and flags anything that's been changed outside of CloudFormation — typically a console click-fix during an incident that nobody rolled back into the template afterward. You trigger it via `aws cloudformation detect-stack-drift`, poll the drift detection status, then pull the per-resource drift results, which show you the actual vs. expected property values. In practice I've used this after 'emergency fixes' — someone bumps an instance type or opens a security group port directly in the console to unblock an incident, which is sometimes the right call in the moment, but drift detection is how you catch that the template no longer reflects reality before the next deployment silently reverts the fix or, worse, someone assumes the template is ground truth when it isn't anymore.

What happens when a CloudFormation stack update fails partway through, and how do you handle it?

q016

By default, CloudFormation automatically rolls back on failure — it attempts to undo every change made so far in that update and return the stack to its last known-good state, which is one of its genuinely nice safety properties compared to some hand-rolled deployment scripts. The stack ends up in `UPDATE_ROLLBACK_FAILED` if even the rollback itself can't complete — commonly because a resource was manually modified outside the stack and CloudFormation can't reconcile it, or an IAM permission needed for the rollback itself is missing. When that happens, you're in `continue-update-rollback` territory: you identify the specific resource that's stuck, sometimes have to tell CloudFormation to skip rolling back that one resource, then reconcile it manually afterward. The practical lesson is: know *why* an update failed — a bad parameter, a resource limit, an IAM permission gap — before blindly retrying, because retrying the same failing update just repeats the same rollback cycle.

Compare CloudFormation and Terraform state management — what's actually different under the hood?

q017

CloudFormation doesn't expose a separate state file to you the way Terraform does — AWS manages the stack's state internally, and you interact with it via stack operations and drift detection rather than editing a state file directly. That's a double-edged trade: you don't have Terraform's classic state-file headaches — no remote backend to configure, no state-locking race conditions, nothing to accidentally commit to git with secrets in it — but you also lose the flexibility Terraform gives you, like `terraform state mv` to reorganize resources without destroying and recreating them, or `terraform import` to bring pre-existing infrastructure under management with fine control over how it's mapped. In Terraform, the state file is the source of truth for what Terraform believes exists, which is exactly why state corruption or a lost state file is such a serious incident — in CloudFormation that specific failure mode simply doesn't exist because AWS itself holds the ground truth.

Given this JD wants a 'heavy focus on CloudFormation with Terraform as well,' how would you decide which tool to use for a given piece of infrastructure?

q018

In an AWS-only shop that's already standardized on CloudFormation, I'd default to CloudFormation for anything AWS-native — it has zero setup overhead (no separate backend/state to provision), gets day-one support for new AWS services, and integrates natively with StackSets for multi-account rollout and with Service Catalog if there's a self-service infrastructure story. I'd reach for Terraform specifically when a piece of infrastructure needs to span providers — say, AWS plus a SaaS DNS provider like Cloudflare or a monitoring SaaS like Datadog configured as code — because Terraform's provider ecosystem handles that uniformly where CloudFormation can't touch non-AWS resources at all. Practically, I wouldn't force a rewrite of working CloudFormation into Terraform just for consistency; I'd follow whatever the existing convention is for a given resource family and only introduce Terraform where it solves a real multi-provider or module-reuse problem the existing CloudFormation setup can't.

TERRAFORM DEPTH

What's the difference between `terraform plan` and `terraform apply`, and what do you always check before applying in production? q019

`plan` computes and shows the diff between current state and desired configuration without touching real infrastructure — it's a dry run. `apply` executes that plan against real infrastructure. Before applying to production I always read the plan output looking specifically for the word `replace` or `force replacement`, since that means a resource gets destroyed and recreated rather than updated in place — for something like an RDS instance or an EKS node group, that's the difference between a routine change and an outage. I also check the resource *count* changes at the top of the plan output match my mental model of what I intended to change — if I expected 2 resources to change and the plan shows 14, something's wrong with my configuration, possibly a for_each/count reindexing issue, and I stop before applying.

Explain the `count` vs `for_each` reindexing gotcha in Terraform. q020

With `count`, Terraform tracks resource instances by numeric index — `resource[0]`, `resource[1]`. If you remove an item from the middle of a list that `count` iterates over, every subsequent item shifts down an index, and Terraform reads that as 'destroy this instance, create a new one at this index' for every item after the removed one — even though logically nothing about those later items actually changed. `for_each` tracks instances by a stable key — typically a map key or a set value — so removing one item only affects that one item's resource; everything else's key is untouched and Terraform correctly sees no change needed for them. The practical rule I follow: use `for_each` over `count` by default for anything where the underlying list of items might grow or shrink over time, and reserve `count` for genuinely fixed-cardinality cases like 'always exactly 3 AZs.'

A colleague marks a sensitive variable with `sensitive = true` in Terraform. Is that variable actually protected? q021

Only partially, and this is a common misunderstanding. `sensitive = true` redacts the value from CLI output — `plan` and `apply` show `(sensitive value)` instead of the real string — but it does **not** encrypt the value inside the state file. If your state is stored in plaintext in an S3 backend without encryption, or someone runs `terraform show` or `terraform state pull`, the actual secret is right there in the state JSON. The real fix is encrypting the state backend itself — S3 server-side encryption plus tightly scoped IAM on the state bucket — and for genuinely sensitive values, sourcing them from Secrets Manager or SSM Parameter Store at apply-time via a data source rather than passing them as plain Terraform variables at all. Newer Terraform versions (1.10/1.11) introduced write-only/ephemeral arguments specifically to address this — a value can be used during apply without ever being persisted into state — which is the more durable fix once you're on a version that supports it.

What's the danger of using `-target` when running Terraform apply? q022

`-target` tells Terraform to apply changes to only a specific resource, deliberately skipping the rest of the dependency graph — it's meant as a narrow escape hatch, not a routine workflow. The danger is that Terraform's normal safety comes from planning the *entire* graph together, catching cross-resource implications; with `-target`, you can end up with state that's inconsistent with your actual configuration, because a resource you didn't target might have depended on something that changed, and Terraform never evaluated that dependency this run. I use `-target` only for genuine emergency scenarios — like unblocking a stuck resource during an incident — and I always follow it up with a full untargeted `plan` immediately after, specifically to see what the targeted apply left out of sync, rather than assuming the targeted change was self-contained.

What does `terraform import` actually do, and what's the catch people miss?

q023

`import` brings an already-existing piece of real infrastructure — something created manually or by another tool — under Terraform's management by writing an entry into the state file that maps a resource address to the real resource's ID. The catch that trips people up constantly: `import` only writes *state*, it does **not** generate the corresponding HCL configuration block for you. If you import a resource into state but haven't already written a matching `resource` block in your `.tf` files with matching arguments, your very next `plan` will show Terraform wanting to change or even destroy that resource — because as far as Terraform's diffing logic is concerned, your configuration says 'this shouldn't exist' or has different settings than what's imported. So the actual workflow is: write the resource block first, matching the real resource's current settings as closely as you can, import it, then run `plan` and iterate on the config until the diff is empty.

What's a Terraform `moved` block, and why would you flag it as high-value in a troubleshooting context?

q024

A `moved` block tells Terraform 'this resource used to be at this address in state, it's now at this new address' — for example, when you refactor a resource into a module and its state address changes from `aws_instance.web` to `module.compute.aws_instance.web`. Without a `moved` block (or the older, more error-prone `terraform state mv` CLI command doing the same thing), Terraform sees the old address disappear and a new address appear in your configuration, and it plans to *destroy* the old resource and *create* a new one at the new address — even though logically it's the exact same EC2 instance, just referenced differently. I flag this as the highest-value gotcha specifically because the failure mode is silent: the plan output doesn't scream 'this could delete a running production database,' it just shows a routine-looking destroy/create pair, and if you don't read it carefully, `apply` genuinely deletes and recreates a resource you only meant to rename.

Concretely, the fix is a couple of lines in the new module, not a state-CLI gymnastics session:

```
moved {
  from = aws_instance.web
  to   = module.compute.aws_instance.web
}
```

Run `terraform plan` after adding it and you should see 'moved' in the output instead of a destroy/create pair — that's the signal the refactor is safe.

IAM & Security

IAM DESIGN

How do you configure IAM policies to be both secure and cost-effective, as the JD phrases it?

q025

I always start from least privilege — scoped resource ARNs and specific actions rather than `*` wildcards — and prefer IAM roles over long-lived IAM user access keys wherever the workload allows it, because roles issue short-lived, automatically-rotated credentials via STS, closing off an entire class of leaked-static-key incidents. For cost-effectiveness specifically, tight IAM is actually a cost control, not a separate concern: over-permissioned roles are how a compromised or buggy workload runs up an unexpected bill — spinning up expensive resources it was never meant to touch. I use permission boundaries on roles that provision other IAM entities, so even a compromised automation role can't escalate its own privileges beyond a defined ceiling, and I review access via IAM Access Analyzer periodically to catch unused permissions that have accumulated over time — because permission creep is the default state of any IAM setup left unmaintained.

What's the difference between an IAM role and an IAM user, and when do you use each?

q026

An IAM user is a persistent identity with long-lived credentials — a password and/or access keys — meant for a human logging into the console or, historically, for applications needing programmatic access. An IAM role has no long-term credentials at all; something *assumes* the role and gets temporary, auto-expiring credentials via STS. My default now is: humans get IAM Identity Center (SSO) federation rather than IAM users at all, and every AWS service or application — EC2 instances, Lambda functions, EKS pods via IRSA — gets a role, never a static access key. The only place I'd still reach for an IAM user with access keys is a genuinely external system that can't assume a role, like a legacy on-prem CI system without OIDC federation support — and even then, I'd push hard for OIDC federation instead, because that specific case is exactly the residual risk long-lived-key IAM users exist to close off.

Can an IAM role be renamed after creation?

q027

No — this is a specific gotcha worth knowing cold. IAM roles cannot be renamed once created; the role name is effectively immutable. If you need a role with a different name, the actual path is: create a new role with the desired name, copy over its trust policy and attached permission policies, update every place that references the old role ARN — EC2 instance profiles, Lambda execution role settings, IRSA annotations on Kubernetes service accounts — then delete the old role once nothing depends on it anymore. IAM *users* and IAM *groups*, by contrast, genuinely can be renamed via the console or `update-user` / `update-group` API calls without recreating them — that asymmetry between roles and users/groups is exactly the kind of small, specific fact that's easy to get wrong under interview pressure if you haven't deliberately memorized it.

How do you set up IAM Roles for Service Accounts (IRSA) for pods running on EKS? q028

IRSA relies on the EKS cluster having an OIDC identity provider associated with it — that's the piece that lets IAM trust tokens issued by the Kubernetes API server. You create an IAM role with a trust policy scoped to that specific OIDC provider and, critically, conditioned on a specific Kubernetes namespace and service account name via the `sub` claim — not just 'trust this cluster' broadly. Then you annotate the Kubernetes ServiceAccount with `eks.amazonaws.com/role-arn` pointing at that role, and any pod using that service account gets a projected token the AWS SDK automatically exchanges for temporary credentials scoped to exactly that role — no static keys anywhere in the cluster. The security win over the older node-instance-profile approach is real isolation: every pod on a node used to inherit whatever permissions the node's own IAM role had, so a compromised pod could reach anything the node could; with IRSA, a pod only gets the specific role its own service account is bound to.

A security review flags that your CI/CD pipeline uses a long-lived AWS access key stored as a GitHub secret. How would you fix that? q029

The proper fix is OIDC federation between GitHub Actions and AWS IAM, which removes the long-lived key entirely. You configure an IAM OIDC identity provider trusting `token.actions.githubusercontent.com`, then an IAM role with a trust policy conditioned on the specific GitHub repo and, ideally, the specific branch or environment — so a workflow run from an unrelated repo can't assume that role even if it somehow knew the role ARN. GitHub Actions' `aws-actions/configure-aws-credentials` action then exchanges the workflow's OIDC token for short-lived STS credentials at the start of the job, valid only for that run. Beyond fixing this one pipeline, I'd treat the finding as a prompt to audit for other long-lived keys sitting in CI secrets across the org, since if one pipeline was set up this way, it's a fair bet others were too, and it's the kind of finding that's worth fixing systematically rather than one-off.

How do you approach security for a service that needs to talk to a third-party API, requiring an API key to be stored somewhere? q030

The API key goes into Secrets Manager, never into an environment variable baked into a container image or a Kubernetes ConfigMap (ConfigMaps aren't encrypted at rest the way Secrets are, and either way baking a secret into an image means it's sitting in every layer of every pulled image forever, including old tags). The workload's IAM role gets `secretsmanager:GetSecretValue` scoped to that one specific secret's ARN — not a wildcard across all secrets — and I'd set up rotation if the third party's API supports key rotation, with the rotation Lambda handling the coordination. I'd also make sure the secret's access shows up in CloudTrail, and if the third-party service is critical enough, I'd keep a documented, tested process for rotating the key manually in an emergency — like if it leaks — rather than discovering during an actual incident that nobody remembers how.

- [ ] **What foundational security knowledge does 'networking, storage, IAM, certificates, logs, and containers' — as this JD's Monitoring section phrases it — actually mean in day-to-day troubleshooting?** q031

  It means when something's broken, I can reason across those layers instead of guessing. Networking: can I actually trace a request's path — security group, NACL, route table, DNS resolution — to find where it's actually being blocked, rather than randomly opening ports until it works. Storage: understanding EBS volume types and their IOPS characteristics, or why an EFS mount might be the bottleneck rather than the application. IAM: reading a policy and correctly predicting whether an action is allowed, including understanding explicit-deny-always-wins and how permission boundaries interact with identity policies. Certificates: knowing the difference between a cert that's expired, one that doesn't match the hostname (SAN mismatch), and one where the chain of trust is broken — because those three produce different-looking TLS errors and need different fixes. Logs: knowing where to actually look — CloudWatch Logs, VPC Flow Logs, ALB access logs, container stdout — before reaching for a dashboard that might not have the specific signal you need. And containers: understanding that a container's exit code and `kubectl describe` events often tell you more than the application log itself does. It's the combination — being able to move across all of them for one incident — that this bullet is really testing.

Kubernetes / EKS

CLUSTER & WORKLOAD MANAGEMENT

How do you approach orchestrating and scaling workloads on Amazon EKS specifically, versus generic Kubernetes knowledge? q032

The EKS-specific layer on top of generic Kubernetes knowledge is mostly about how the control plane and node lifecycle are managed by AWS versus self-hosted. The control plane itself is fully managed — I don't patch etcd or the API server — but I'm responsible for node groups (managed node groups or self-managed via Auto Scaling Groups, or Fargate for pods that don't need node-level control), the aws-node CNI plugin for pod networking, and the aws-auth ConfigMap that maps IAM identities to Kubernetes RBAC. For scaling specifically, I'd combine the Kubernetes-native Horizontal Pod Autoscaler reacting to CPU/memory or custom metrics with Cluster Autoscaler or Karpenter reacting to unschedulable pods by provisioning new EC2 capacity — Karpenter specifically because it provisions nodes faster and with tighter bin-packing than the older Cluster Autoscaler, which matters for cost when workloads scale up and down frequently.

A pod is stuck in `Pending` state on EKS. Walk me through your diagnosis process. q033

First move is always `kubectl describe pod <name>` and read the Events section at the bottom — that's where the scheduler tells you *why* it can't place the pod, and guessing before reading that is wasted time. Common causes in order of frequency: insufficient resources — the requested CPU/memory doesn't fit on any current node, which either needs Cluster Autoscaler/Karpenter to provision a new node or points to over-requested resource specs; a taint on every available node that the pod doesn't tolerate; a PersistentVolumeClaim that can't be bound, often because the requested storage class or AZ doesn't have matching capacity; or node selectors/affinity rules that don't match any node's labels. I'd check `kubectl get nodes` for capacity and `kubectl describe node` on likely candidates to see what's already allocated there, cross-referencing against what the pending pod is actually asking for.

What's the difference between a pod being `Running` and being `Ready`, and why does that distinction matter operationally? q034

`Running` just means the container process has started inside the pod — the OS-level process exists. `Ready` means the container has passed its readiness probe, which is Kubernetes' way of asking 'is this actually able to serve traffic right now.' The operational consequence: a Service only routes traffic to pods that are Ready, not merely Running — so an application that starts its process instantly but takes 30 seconds to warm up a connection pool or load a cache needs a readiness probe that reflects that, or Kubernetes will send it live traffic before it can actually handle it, causing a burst of errors right at rollout. I've seen this bite teams specifically during deployments: a rolling update looks 'successful' because new pods show Running, but real users are hitting 500s for those 30 seconds because nobody wired up a proper readiness probe distinct from the liveness probe.

Explain Kubernetes' liveness vs readiness vs startup probes, and a mistake you'd watch for in how they're configured. q035

Liveness answers 'is this container alive, or should it be killed and restarted' — a failing liveness probe triggers a container restart. Readiness answers 'should this pod currently receive traffic' — a failing readiness probe pulls the pod out of Service endpoints without restarting anything. Startup probes exist for slow-starting applications, delaying when liveness/readiness even begin checking, so a legitimately slow boot doesn't get mistaken for a hang and killed prematurely. The mistake I watch for: using the *same* check and timing for liveness and readiness. If an application temporarily can't reach its database — a transient dependency issue, not the application itself being broken — a shared, aggressive liveness probe will restart the container repeatedly even though restarting does nothing to fix a downstream dependency; that just adds restart-storm noise on top of an already-degraded dependency. Liveness should check 'is my own process healthy,' readiness should check 'can I currently serve requests including dependencies' — deliberately different questions.

A Deployment's pods keep getting recreated even though you didn't trigger a new rollout. What's going on? q036

This is the Deployment-managed pod recreation gotcha — a Deployment's whole job is to continuously reconcile the actual pod count and spec against its desired state, so anything that deletes a pod directly, or any change to the Deployment's pod template (even an indirect one, like a ConfigMap referenced via a checksum annotation, or a change to the underlying node causing eviction) triggers the ReplicaSet controller to create a replacement. I'd check `kubectl rollout history` and `kubectl describe deployment` first to see if a rollout is actually in progress that someone forgot they triggered; if not, I'd check for node-level events — node pressure, spot instance interruption, or a Cluster Autoscaler scale-down consolidating pods onto fewer nodes — since those cause pod eviction and recreation without ever touching the Deployment object directly, and it's easy to misread that as 'something's wrong with my Deployment' when the actual cause is one layer down at the node.

How does a Kubernetes Service find `no endpoints`, and what would you check? q037

'No endpoints' means the Service's label selector doesn't currently match any Ready pod — the Service object itself is fine, but there's nothing behind it for traffic to actually reach. First check: `kubectl get endpoints <service-name>` to confirm it's genuinely empty, then compare the Service's `selector` labels against the actual labels on the pods you expect it to route to — a typo or a label that changed during a refactor is the single most common cause. If labels match, the next check is whether those pods are actually Ready — a Service only populates endpoints from Ready pods, so if every matching pod is failing its readiness probe, you'll see zero endpoints even though pods that match the selector clearly exist and are Running. I'd also double check I'm not accidentally looking at the wrong namespace, since a default-namespace mismatch between a CI-deployed resource and where you're querying is a surprisingly common self-inflicted version of this exact symptom.

What's Kubernetes' requests-vs-limits model, and a subtlety people get wrong?

q038

`requests` is what the scheduler guarantees a pod when placing it on a node — it's used for bin-packing decisions. `limits` is the hard ceiling a container can't exceed — CPU gets throttled, memory over the limit gets the container OOMKilled. The subtlety: if you set a memory `limit` but no memory `request`, Kubernetes doesn't leave the request unspecified — depending on the QoS class semantics, an unset request effectively defaults in a way that can leave the scheduler under-provisioning for that pod's actual needs, and it also puts the pod in a lower, more eviction-prone QoS class (`Burstable` rather than `Guaranteed`) than teams often assume they're getting. The other common mistake is setting CPU limits too tight on a JVM-based workload specifically — CPU throttling on the JVM can cause GC pauses to stretch out in ways that look like an application hang rather than an obvious 'out of CPU' signal, which is a genuinely confusing debugging trap if you don't know to check `kubectl top pod` against the configured limit first.

Docker & Helm

IMAGE CREATION & OPTIMIZATION

☐ The JD emphasizes 'image creation and optimization' specifically for Docker. What does optimization actually mean to you in practice? q039

Three concrete things, in order of typical impact. First, multi-stage builds — compile or build your artifact in a heavier build-stage image that has the full toolchain, then copy only the final artifact into a minimal runtime-stage image (distroless or alpine-based), so the shipped image doesn't carry compilers, package manager caches, or build-time dependencies at all. Second, layer ordering — putting things that change rarely (base image, OS packages, dependency installation) *before* things that change often (your actual application code) in the Dockerfile, so Docker's build cache is actually useful and a code-only change doesn't force a full dependency reinstall on every build. Third, being deliberate with `.dockerignore` so build context and layers aren't bloated with `.git`, local `node_modules`, or test fixtures that have no business being in a production image. On a Java/Spring Boot image specifically — relevant given this JD's 'good to have' — layering the fat JAR's dependencies separately from the application classes using Spring Boot's layered JAR support gets you much better cache reuse than copying one monolithic JAR.

☐ What's the difference between `COPY` and `ADD` in a Dockerfile, and which should you default to? q040

`ADD` does everything `COPY` does, plus two extra behaviors: it can fetch a remote URL directly, and it automatically extracts local tar archives into the destination. Those extra behaviors are exactly why I default to `COPY` for the common case of just moving local files into the image — `ADD`'s auto-extraction and URL-fetching are implicit behavior that can surprise someone reading the Dockerfile later, and fetching a URL at build time means your build isn't fully reproducible from the archived source alone, plus it skips any checksum or provenance verification you'd normally want on a downloaded artifact. I'd only reach for `ADD` for its one genuinely useful case — extracting a local tarball as part of image assembly — and even then I'd add a comment explaining why, since it's non-obvious behavior compared to the far more common `COPY`.

☐ A container keeps its old state even after you thought you cleaned it up with `docker rm`. What happened? q041

This is usually the exec-survives-restart-not-rm gotcha, though it can show up a couple of different ways. If someone `docker exec`'d into a running container and made changes to the filesystem inside it, those changes live in the container's writable layer, and a `docker restart` preserves that writable layer — restart doesn't reset the container to the image's pristine state, only `docker rm` followed by `docker run` from the image fresh does that. So if the expectation was 'restarting resets everything,' that's the wrong mental model for Docker containers — the image is immutable, but a *running container's* writable layer is not, and it persists across restarts. I'd flag this as a broader lesson too: any manual `exec`-based fix during an incident needs to either be followed up with a proper image/config change so it survives a real redeploy, or explicitly documented as a temporary patch that'll be lost — otherwise you get exactly this kind of confusing 'it's still doing the old thing' surprise.

☐ Explain how Docker's build cache and layer ordering actually work, and why Dockerfile order matters so much. q042

Docker builds an image as a stack of layers, one per instruction, and caches each layer keyed roughly on that instruction plus the state of the layer before it. When you rebuild, Docker walks the Dockerfile top to bottom and reuses cached layers until it hits the first instruction whose inputs have changed — from that point on, every subsequent layer is rebuilt from scratch, cache or no cache, because the layer *before* it changed. That's exactly why ordering matters: if you `COPY . .` (your whole application source) before running `npm install` or `pip install`, then any single source-code change invalidates the cache for the dependency-install layer too, even though your dependencies didn't actually change — forcing a full reinstall on every build. Correct ordering is: copy just the dependency manifest (`package.json`, `requirements.txt`, `pom.xml`) first, install dependencies, *then* copy the rest of the source — so dependency installation stays cached across ordinary code changes and only re-runs when the manifest itself changes.

HELM CHARTS

☐ What does it mean to 'package and maintain applications using Helm Charts,' as this JD phrases it — what's actually in a well-structured chart? q043

A chart's skeleton is `Chart.yaml` (metadata — name, version, app version), `values.yaml` (the default configuration a consumer can override), and a `templates/` directory holding the actual Kubernetes manifests written as Go templates that reference values. Maintaining it well means designing `values.yaml` as a genuine, documented interface — sensible defaults, clear comments on what each value controls, and consistent naming conventions across templates — rather than just dumping every hardcoded string from a raw manifest into a template variable. I'd also lean on Helm's built-in helpers (`_helpers.tpl`) for anything repeated across multiple templates, like standard label sets, so a naming-convention change is a one-line edit instead of a multi-file find-and-replace. And versioning discipline matters: bumping the chart version on any templates/values-schema change, separately from bumping appVersion when just the application image tag changes, so consumers of the chart can tell at a glance whether an upgrade changes the chart's *interface* or just its *contents*.

☐ How does Helm handle updates to a ConfigMap that a Deployment references — does changing the ConfigMap automatically restart the pods? q044

No, and this trips people up constantly — updating a ConfigMap's contents does **not** by itself cause pods that mount it to restart or even reload it, unless the application inside the pod is specifically watching the mounted file for changes (some apps do this, most don't). The standard Helm pattern to force a rollout when config changes is the checksum-annotation trick: adding an annotation to the pod template, like `checksum/config: {{ include (print $.Template.BasePath '/configmap.yaml') . | sha256sum }}`, so that whenever the rendered ConfigMap content changes, the pod template's annotation value changes too, which *does* trigger the Deployment controller to see a spec diff and roll the pods — effectively forcing a restart as a side effect of the annotation changing, since Kubernetes has no built-in 'restart on ConfigMap change' primitive of its own.

What's the trade-off between a single monolithic Helm chart for a whole application stack versus one chart per microservice? q045

One chart per microservice keeps each service's release cycle, versioning, and rollback fully independent — you can deploy service A without touching service B's release at all, which matters once you have enough services that coordinated deploys become a bottleneck. The cost is more repetition across charts (mitigated with a shared library chart for common templates) and no single command that deploys 'the whole stack' coherently — you'd need something like a Helm umbrella chart or a separate orchestration layer (Argo CD app-of-apps, for instance) for that. A single monolithic chart gives you atomic, whole-stack deploys and less duplication, but couples every service's release cadence together and makes the chart itself grow unwieldy as the number of services increases. I'd lean toward per-service charts plus an umbrella/app-of-apps pattern once a team has more than a handful of independently-owned services — which is the more common shape for a services/product-studio context like this JD's.

CI/CD & Git Workflow

GIT WORKFLOW & BRANCHING

☐ The JD says GitHub is 'mandatory' with an emphasis on 'advanced branching strategies and code reviews.' Walk me through a branching strategy you'd actually implement. q046

For most product-engineering-style teams I'd default to trunk-based development with short-lived feature branches over a long-lived Git Flow model — feature branches live a day or two at most, merge into `main` behind a pull request, and `main` is always deployable. Git Flow's long-lived `develop`/`release`/`hotfix` branches make sense for a slower, versioned-release cadence like packaged software with discrete version numbers, but for a continuously-deployed service they tend to accumulate painful, large merge conflicts and delay integration feedback. Branch protection on `main` is non-negotiable — required PR reviews, required status checks (tests, linting) passing before merge, and no direct pushes, including from admins, because that last one specifically closes off the 'branch-protection-admin-bypass' gotcha where an admin's ability to override protection rules gets used as a routine shortcut instead of a genuine emergency escape hatch.

☐ What makes a good code review, from your side as both reviewer and author? q047

As a reviewer, I focus on things a linter or test suite genuinely can't catch: does this change actually solve the stated problem, are there edge cases the tests don't cover, does this introduce a security or IAM-scope concern, and is it something the *team* — not just the author — will be able to maintain in six months. I try to separate 'this is objectively wrong' from 'this is a style preference,' and I'm explicit about which is which in comments, because conflating them either slows down good work over bikeshedding or lets a real issue slide because it was phrased too gently. As an author, I try to keep PRs small and single-purpose specifically so a reviewer can hold the whole change in their head — a 40-file PR touching five unrelated things basically guarantees a rubber-stamp review, which defeats the entire point of having review gates in the first place.

☐ Your GitHub Actions CI passes and shows green, but the application is actually broken in production. What's your first thought? q048

That green-pipeline-doesn't-equal-healthy is a very real gap, and it usually means the test suite's coverage doesn't match production's actual failure surface — most commonly, integration or contract issues with a downstream dependency that unit tests mock out entirely, or an environment-specific config difference between CI and production (a feature flag, a resource limit, a data volume CI never sees) that the tests simply can't exercise. My first move is checking what actually differs between the CI environment and production — dependency versions, environment variables, external service behavior — rather than assuming the tests were 'wrong,' because often they were correctly testing exactly what they were written to test, and the gap is that nobody wrote a test for this particular failure mode yet. Long-term, I'd treat each production incident that CI didn't catch as a prompt to add the missing test or check, specifically so that category of failure gets caught by CI next time instead of shipping to production again.

☐ What CI/CD pipeline gotcha have you personally been bitten by, involving container image tags? q049

The `:latest` tag combined with a default `imagePullPolicy` is a classic one. If a Deployment's image is tagged `:latest` and `imagePullPolicy` isn't explicitly set to `Always`, Kubernetes' default behavior for the `:latest` tag specifically *is* `Always` — so that particular combination actually does pull fresh each time, which is itself a separate problem: two pods started at slightly different times, or a node restart pulling a newer `:latest` than what's already running elsewhere, can end up running genuinely different code under the identical `:latest` label, making 'what's actually deployed right now' unanswerable from the tag alone. The fix I insist on is immutable, unique tags per build — a git SHA or a semantic version — never deploying `:latest` to any environment that matters, so the image tag itself is a reliable, auditable record of exactly what's running, and a rollback is just 'redeploy the previous known-good tag' rather than a guessing game.

CI/CD TOOLING

☐ Compare GitHub Actions, Jenkins, and Concourse as CI/CD engines — when would you reach for each? q050

GitHub Actions is my default when the repo already lives on GitHub, because there's zero separate infrastructure to run and maintain, the marketplace of reusable actions covers most common needs, and OIDC federation to AWS is first-class — which matters a lot given how much IAM/security discipline this JD cares about. Jenkins earns its place when you need something highly customizable that Actions' YAML-and-marketplace model doesn't comfortably support — deeply bespoke pipeline logic, on-prem/air-gapped environments where a SaaS-hosted runner genuinely can't reach your infrastructure, or a large existing plugin ecosystem a team has already invested years into. Concourse is the least common of the three in my experience, but its core idea — pipelines as fully declarative YAML resources with no persistent build-agent state leaking between runs — makes every build genuinely reproducible in a way that's harder to guarantee with Jenkins' more stateful agent model; I'd expect to see it in a team that's specifically prioritized pipeline reproducibility and has the appetite for its steeper learning curve.

☐ What does a robust CI/CD pipeline actually consist of, beyond just 'build and deploy'? q051

Build (compile/package, ideally producing an immutable, uniquely-tagged artifact), automated tests at multiple levels — unit tests fast and on every commit, integration tests against real or realistic dependencies, and security scanning (dependency CVE scanning, container image scanning) as a gate rather than an afterthought — then a deployment stage that itself has a strategy, not just 'kubectl apply and hope': blue-green or canary rather than an all-at-once rollout for anything production-facing, with automated rollback criteria tied to real health signals (error rate, latency) rather than a human having to notice something's wrong and manually intervene. I'd also insist on the pipeline itself being version-controlled and reviewable the same way application code is — a pipeline definition living only in a CI tool's UI, undocumented and unreviewed, is exactly the kind of thing that becomes a single point of tribal-knowledge failure.

How do you prevent secrets from leaking into CI/CD logs?

q052

Most CI systems, GitHub Actions included, automatically mask registered secret values in log output — but that masking only works if the exact registered string appears verbatim; if a script transforms or partially exposes the secret (like base64-encoding it, or echoing a substring), the masking can fail to catch it, which is a subtler leak vector than people expect. I'd never `echo` a secret directly for debugging, even temporarily, since that habit is exactly how leaks happen — someone adds a debug echo, forgets to remove it, and it ships to a shared, often long-retained CI log. I'd also make sure secrets are scoped as narrowly as possible — repository or environment-level rather than organization-wide — so a leak in one pipeline doesn't expose credentials for every other project, and I'd treat any suspected secret leak in logs as an immediate rotation event rather than just deleting the log, since logs can be cached, retained by the CI provider, or already scraped before you noticed.

You have two deployments running concurrently — one triggered manually, one by a scheduled pipeline run — and they race against each other. How do you prevent that?

q053

This is the concurrent-deploy-race gotcha, and the fix is a deployment lock or concurrency control at the pipeline level, not something you can reliably solve with timing or 'just don't do that.' GitHub Actions has a native `concurrency` key you can set at the workflow or job level — if a new run starts while one with the same concurrency group is in flight, you configure whether the new run queues behind it or cancels the in-progress one, and either behavior is safer than letting two deploys interleave arbitrarily. For infrastructure changes specifically, Terraform's remote state locking (via DynamoDB for an S3 backend) provides a similar guarantee at the state level — a second `apply` targeting the same state simply can't proceed until the first one releases the lock. I'd apply the same principle everywhere a deploy touches shared, mutable state: make the race structurally impossible rather than relying on people coordinating manually, because manual coordination is exactly what fails under real operational pressure.

Automation Scripting

PYTHON, BASH & POWERSHELL

☐ The JD asks for automation scripts in Python, Bash, *or* PowerShell 'to improve deployment consistency.' How do you decide which language to reach for?

q054

Bash for anything that's genuinely a thin, linear wrapper around existing CLI tools — chaining `aws`, `kubectl`, `helm` commands together in a CI step — since it has zero extra dependencies and is exactly what a CI runner already has available. Python once there's real logic involved — conditionals, error handling that needs to be more structured than checking `$?`, parsing and transforming JSON/YAML output, or anything I'd want unit tests for — because `boto3` gives direct, well-typed API access rather than shelling out to the AWS CLI and parsing text output, which is both faster and far less fragile against CLI output-format changes. PowerShell specifically for the Windows-host side of this JD's 'diverse infrastructure' — because that's where it's genuinely the native, first-class tool, with direct access to Windows-specific concepts like the registry, WMI, and Active Directory cmdlets that Bash or Python would need extra libraries to approximate. I try not to force one language everywhere out of personal preference; the deployment target and the complexity of the logic should decide it.

☐ Give a concrete example of a Bash automation habit that improves deployment consistency, and why it matters.

q055

`set -euo pipefail` at the top of every deployment script, which is a small habit with an outsized payoff. `-e` exits immediately on any command failure instead of silently continuing past it; `-u` treats an unset variable reference as an error instead of silently substituting an empty string, which has caused real incidents — like an unset environment variable making a destructive command target an empty path that resolves to something unintended; `-o pipefail` makes a pipeline's exit code reflect the *first* failing command in the chain rather than just the last one, since by default Bash only looks at the last command's exit code and will happily report success even if an earlier command in a pipe silently failed. Without all three, a deployment script can appear to succeed — exit code 0, green in CI — while having actually failed part way through, which is exactly the kind of false-confidence failure mode that erodes trust in automation.

A minimal deployment script header I'd actually write:

```
#!/usr/bin/env bash
set -euo pipefail

ENVIRONMENT="${1:?Usage: deploy.sh <environment>}"
AWS_REGION="${AWS_REGION:-ap-south-1}"

echo "Deploying to ${ENVIRONMENT} in ${AWS_REGION}..."
aws cloudformation deploy \
  --template-file infra/template.yaml \
  --stack-name "app-${ENVIRONMENT}" \
  --parameter-overrides Environment="${ENVIRONMENT}" \
  --capabilities CAPABILITY_NAMED_IAM \
  --no-fail-on-empty-changeset
```

The `${1:?...}` pattern is worth calling out on its own — it fails fast with a clear message if the environment argument is missing, instead of silently proceeding with an empty string that could target the wrong stack.

Walk me through a Python script pattern you'd use to make AWS automation idempotent — safely re-runnable without causing duplicate resources or errors.

q056

The core pattern with `boto3` is always checking current state before acting, rather than assuming a fresh environment: for example, before creating an S3 bucket, calling `head_bucket` first and catching the specific `404` / `403` exceptions to distinguish 'doesn't exist, safe to create' from 'exists but I don't have permission to check it' — those need different handling, not a blanket try/except that swallows both. For anything that genuinely needs to represent 'either create or update to match this desired state,' I lean toward that being exactly what Terraform or CloudFormation already do well, and I try not to reinvent a shakier version of declarative state reconciliation in raw Python when an IaC tool already solves it properly — Python scripts earn their keep for orchestration and glue logic *around* the IaC, like triggering a pipeline, posting a Slack notification, or querying multiple AWS accounts and aggregating results, not for being a second, parallel source of infrastructure truth.

What's your approach to error handling and logging in an automation script that runs unattended, say as a scheduled Lambda or a cron job?

q057

Structured logging over free-text — JSON log lines with consistent fields (timestamp, script name, action, resource ID, outcome) so CloudWatch Logs Insights or whatever's aggregating logs can actually query and alert on them, rather than someone having to `grep` and eyeball raw text later during an incident. Every external call — an AWS API call, an HTTP request to another service — gets wrapped with explicit handling for the failure modes that are actually likely: throttling (with exponential backoff and jitter, not a fixed retry delay that can itself contribute to a thundering-herd retry storm), transient network failures, and permission errors, with permission errors specifically *not* silently retried, since retrying a permission failure just wastes time and obscures a real, non-transient problem that needs a human to fix the underlying IAM policy. And critically: the script's failure mode should be loud, not silent — an unattended automation script that fails quietly and nobody notices for two weeks is arguably worse than no automation at all, because people stop manually checking the thing it was supposed to be doing.

How would you use PowerShell to automate a task on a Windows host managed via AWS Systems Manager, without needing to RDP in?

q058

SSM's `Run Command` with the `AWS-RunPowerShellScript` document is the standard path — you target instances by tag or instance ID, and SSM executes the PowerShell script directly via the SSM Agent already running on the instance, with output captured back to CloudWatch Logs or an S3 bucket rather than needing interactive RDP access at all, which is also a security win since it means you don't need inbound RDP (port 3389) open on those hosts in the first place. For anything that needs to be idempotent and declarative rather than a one-off imperative script — enforcing a specific Windows feature is installed, a registry key is set to a specific value, a service is running — I'd reach for SSM State Manager with a Desired State Configuration (DSC) document instead of a raw Run Command script, since DSC is built specifically for 'converge this host to this state and keep it there,' which is the more maintainable pattern than a one-shot script that only fixes things at the moment it happens to run.

Linux & Windows Hybrid Ops

CROSS-PLATFORM ADMINISTRATION

Give an example of core Linux administration tasks you'd expect to handle regularly in this role. q059

Day-to-day: reading and correlating logs across `journalctl` / `/var/log` for systemd-managed services, managing file permissions and ownership correctly (understanding the difference between a permission problem and an ownership problem, since they look similar but need different fixes), diagnosing resource exhaustion with `top` / `htop`, `df` / `du`, and `free`, and managing systemd units — starting, stopping, checking `systemctl status` for why a service failed to start, which usually points you straight at the actual error rather than needing to hunt through logs first. For anything text-processing heavy — parsing a log file for a specific pattern across time, extracting fields from structured output — `awk`, `sed`, and `grep` are still faster and more universally available than reaching for a Python script for a one-off investigation, so I keep that muscle memory current rather than defaulting to a heavier tool for every small task.

How does Windows host administration differ from Linux in ways that actually matter for a DevOps engineer supporting both? q060

The biggest practical difference is the mental model around services and patching. Windows services are managed via the Service Control Manager rather than systemd, and troubleshooting starts with Windows Event Viewer (Application, System, and Security logs) rather than `/var/log` or `journalctl` — those are genuinely different tools with different query syntax, not just a renamed equivalent. Patching is a much bigger operational event on Windows than on most Linux distros — Windows Update patches frequently require a reboot, so you need a real maintenance-window strategy (Patch Manager's maintenance windows, staggered by fleet segment) rather than the more continuous, often reboot-free patching pattern common on Linux. And permissions work fundamentally differently — Windows ACLs on NTFS are far more granular and inheritance-based than Unix's owner/group/other model, which matters when diagnosing a 'why can't this service account write to this folder' issue, since the answer is almost never as simple as `chmod`.

How do you troubleshoot a network connectivity issue layer by layer? q061

I work up the OSI stack rather than guessing at the application layer first, since that's where people waste the most time. Physical/link layer is rarely my concern in AWS since it's abstracted away, so I start at network: can the source reach the destination IP at all — security groups (stateful, evaluated as an allow-list) and NACLs (stateless, evaluated in rule-number order, and this distinction genuinely matters for troubleshooting) are the first two things I check, followed by route tables to confirm a valid path actually exists between the subnets involved. Then DNS — is the hostname resolving to the IP I expect, using `dig` or `nslookup`, since a surprising number of 'connectivity' issues are actually DNS resolution issues wearing a network-issue costume. Then transport — is the port actually open and listening on the destination, checkable with `nc -zv` or a security-group rule review. Only once all of that checks out do I move to the application layer — is the service itself actually healthy and responding correctly — because debugging application-layer symptoms before confirming the network path is fine is how people chase phantom application bugs that are actually a blocked security group.

What's your process for basic subnetting and CIDR math when designing or troubleshooting a VPC?

q062

I think in terms of how many usable hosts a given prefix length actually gives you, and I keep the common ones memorized rather than recalculating from scratch every time: a `/24` gives 256 addresses total, 251 usable inside a VPC once you subtract AWS's reserved 5 addresses per subnet (network address, VPC router, DNS, future use, and broadcast — though AWS doesn't use classic broadcast, it still reserves that address). A `/28` gives 16 total, 11 usable — tight, and a common trap for something like a small NAT-gateway-only subnet that someone later tries to cram more resources into than it can hold. For troubleshooting, the two things I check are whether subnets across AZs genuinely don't overlap (a classic copy-paste-and-forget-to-change-the-third-octet mistake when adding a new AZ) and whether a subnet actually has enough headroom for its expected growth — auto-scaling into a nearly-full `/26` subnet is a real, if unglamorous, way to cause a production incident that looks like an autoscaling failure but is actually just running out of IP addresses.

How do you patch a mixed fleet of Linux and Windows hosts without causing an availability incident?

q063

Staggered maintenance windows segmented by fleet role, never patching every instance of a given tier simultaneously — for a load-balanced tier, patch a subset, confirm health checks stay green and error rates stay flat, then proceed to the next batch, rather than an all-at-once patch that, if something goes wrong, takes down the whole tier at once with no healthy capacity left to absorb traffic. For Linux, Systems Manager Patch Manager handles this well with patch baselines and maintenance windows; for Windows the same SSM tooling applies, but I'd budget explicitly for the fact that a meaningful fraction of Windows patches require a reboot, so the maintenance window needs enough slack for reboot-and-recovery time per batch, not just the patch-install time itself. I'd also always confirm rollback capability — a recent AMI or snapshot to fall back to — *before* starting a patch cycle on anything stateful, not as an afterthought if something goes wrong mid-patch.

Monitoring — Grafana & Prometheus

OBSERVABILITY PRACTICE

☐ How do you set up Prometheus to monitor an EKS cluster and the applications running on it? q064

Prometheus scrapes metrics via a pull model — it needs targets exposing a `/metrics` endpoint in its text-based exposition format. For cluster-level metrics I'd run `kube-state-metrics` for Kubernetes object state (deployment replica counts, pod status) and `node-exporter` as a DaemonSet for host-level metrics (CPU, memory, disk) on every node. For application-level metrics, the application itself needs to expose a `/metrics` endpoint using a client library appropriate to its language, and I'd configure `ServiceMonitor` or `PodMonitor` custom resources (assuming the Prometheus Operator is in use, which is the standard way to run Prometheus on Kubernetes now) so Prometheus auto-discovers new scrape targets as pods come and go, rather than hand-maintaining a static scrape config that goes stale the moment the pod set changes.

☐ Explain the difference between the RED and USE monitoring methodologies, and when you'd apply each. q065

RED — Rate, Errors, Duration — is oriented at request-driven services: how many requests per second, what fraction are erroring, and how long are they taking (usually as percentiles, not just an average, since averages hide the p99 tail that's actually hurting real users). USE — Utilization, Saturation, Errors — is oriented at resources: how utilized is this resource, is it saturated (queued/backed-up work waiting), and is it erroring. I'd apply RED to anything that serves requests — an API, a web service — since that's what actually reflects user-facing health, and USE to the underlying infrastructure it runs on — CPU, disk I/O, network — since that's what explains *why* RED metrics might be degrading. The two are complementary rather than competing: RED tells you something's wrong from the user's perspective, USE helps you find which underlying resource is actually the bottleneck causing it.

☐ How would you design a Grafana dashboard for an SRE on-call rotation, as opposed to a dashboard meant for engineering leadership? q066

An on-call dashboard needs to answer 'is something wrong right now, and where' in about five seconds — RED-style golden signals up top, error budget burn rate, and a handful of the most common root-cause indicators (node health, recent deploys correlated against the same time axis) all on one screen without needing to click through multiple panels during a live incident. A leadership-facing dashboard is a completely different job: trends over weeks or months, SLO compliance percentage against target, cost trends, and incident *frequency and MTTR* over time — none of which anyone needs to see at 3 AM mid-incident. I've made the mistake early in my career of building one dashboard trying to serve both audiences, and it ends up mediocre at both jobs — too noisy and slow to parse for on-call, too granular and technical for a leadership review; I keep them deliberately separate now.

What's alert fatigue, and how have you reduced it in a previous role?

q067

Alert fatigue is when the volume and noise-to-signal ratio of alerts gets high enough that people start reflexively dismissing or muting them, which is dangerous because it means the *real* critical alert, when it finally comes, gets the same reduced attention as the routine noise around it. At Terawe, working on the Azure Synapse Analytics platform for a Microsoft client, I drove a 40% reduction in alert noise by auditing existing alert rules for ones that fired on transient blips rather than sustained problems — adding proper `for` duration windows so an alert only fires after a condition persists for a meaningful period, not on a single noisy data point — and consolidating multiple related low-level alerts into fewer, higher-signal composite alerts that actually corresponded to a real actionable problem. The other lever, beyond that specific number, is a strict severity-tier discipline: something is either genuinely page-worthy at 3 AM or it's not, and if it's not, it goes to a dashboard or a ticket queue, not someone's phone.

How do you decide what to actually alert on, versus what just belongs on a dashboard?

q068

The test I apply: would a human need to take action on this *right now*, and is there actually something a human *can* do about it immediately? If both are true, it's an alert — ideally a page. If it's informational, or self-healing, or something nobody can meaningfully act on at 3 AM even if they wanted to, it belongs on a dashboard for later review, not in someone's pocket waking them up. I also test new alerts before fully trusting them in production — deliberately triggering the condition in a non-production environment to confirm the alert actually fires, routes to the right place, and contains enough context in the notification itself (which service, which metric, a link to the relevant dashboard) that whoever's paged doesn't have to spend the first five minutes of an incident just figuring out what the alert even means.

What's a burn-rate alert for an SLO, and why is it better than a simple threshold alert on the SLI itself?

q069

A burn-rate alert measures how fast you're consuming your error budget relative to your SLO window, rather than just checking whether the current error rate crossed some fixed threshold at this instant. The advantage is it catches both slow, sustained low-level problems and fast, severe ones at appropriately different urgencies — a short-window, high-burn-rate alert catches 'we're about to blow through a month's error budget in the next hour,' which needs an immediate page, while a longer-window, lower-burn-rate alert catches a slower degradation that's still worth fixing but doesn't need someone woken up at 3 AM for it. A simple fixed threshold on the raw SLI doesn't distinguish those two urgencies at all — it just says 'error rate is above X right now,' which either pages too aggressively for a brief blip or misses a slow-burning problem that never crosses the instantaneous threshold but is still on track to blow the SLO by end of month.

Databases — PostgreSQL & Elastic

POSTGRESQL & ELASTICSEARCH OPS

☐ The JD calls out 'databases such as PostgreSQL and Elastic' specifically. From an ops/DevOps perspective, not a DBA perspective, what do you actually need to know about PostgreSQL? q070

I'd frame my PostgreSQL knowledge honestly as operational, not deep DBA-level query tuning — I'm not writing complex query plans by hand, but I own everything around keeping it healthy and available. That means: connection pooling (PgBouncer, since Postgres' per-connection process model makes it expensive to just let application connection counts scale unbounded), understanding `pg_stat_activity` to spot long-running or blocking queries during an incident, backup/restore strategy (continuous WAL archiving plus periodic base backups, and — critically — actually testing restores periodically rather than assuming backups work), and on AWS specifically, RDS/Aurora Multi-AZ failover behavior, read replica lag monitoring, and connection-limit tuning against instance size. If a question needs genuine query-optimization depth, I'd be upfront that's where I'd loop in someone with deeper DBA expertise rather than overstating my own depth there.

☐ How does Aurora PostgreSQL failover actually work under the hood, and how long does it typically take? q071

Aurora's storage layer is already replicated across multiple AZs independently of the compute/database instances sitting on top of it, so a failover isn't a data-copy event — it's a *promotion* of an existing read replica to become the new writer, since that replica already has access to the same shared, distributed storage volume. That's why Aurora failover is typically well under 30 seconds, versus traditional RDS Multi-AZ (non-Aurora) which does a genuine storage-level failover to a physically separate standby and typically takes longer. Applications need to handle the brief connection interruption gracefully — using the cluster's reader/writer endpoints rather than hardcoding a specific instance's endpoint is essential here, since the writer endpoint automatically re-points at whichever instance is currently promoted, so the application doesn't need to know or care which physical instance is currently the writer.

☐ What would you check first if an application starts throwing 'too many connections' errors against a PostgreSQL database? q072

First, `pg_stat_activity` to see the actual current connection count and, critically, what those connections are *doing* — idle, idle-in-transaction, or actively running a query — since 'idle in transaction' connections are a specific, common culprit: an application that opened a transaction and never committed or rolled it back, silently holding a connection slot indefinitely. If it's a genuine volume problem rather than leaked connections, I'd check whether PgBouncer or another connection pooler is actually in front of the database and correctly configured — a surprising number of 'too many connections' incidents trace back to an application scaling out its pod count without anyone updating the corresponding connection-pool size limits, so the total connections across all pods multiplies past what the database's `max_connections` allows. Longer-term, I'd push for connection pooling to be the default architecture rather than a reactive fix applied only after the first incident.

What's your experience thinking about Elasticsearch from an operations standpoint — cluster health, shard management, that kind of thing? q073

Cluster health status — green/yellow/red — is the first thing I'd check, and I'd know what each actually means operationally: yellow typically means replica shards aren't allocated (often just because you're running a single-node cluster in a lower environment, which is expected there but a real red flag in production), red means primary shards are unassigned, which means some data is genuinely unavailable right now, not just under-replicated. I'd watch shard sizing specifically — too many small shards wastes cluster overhead per-shard, too few large shards makes rebalancing and recovery slow and memory-heavy after a node failure — and I'd keep an eye on JVM heap usage on the data nodes, since Elasticsearch is famously heap-hungry and a heap that's too small relative to data volume leads to frequent, expensive garbage collection pauses that manifest as slow or timed-out queries. I'd frame this the same way as Postgres — solid operational fluency, and I'd defer to deeper search-relevance/mapping-design expertise if a question went that specific.

Production Troubleshooting Scenarios

REAL-WORLD INCIDENTS

☐ Production is down. Walk me through your first five minutes.

q074

First, confirm the blast radius before doing anything else — is this everyone, one region, one AZ, one specific service — because that immediately narrows the likely cause and, just as importantly, tells me who needs to be looped in right now versus who can wait. Second, check what changed recently — a deploy, a config change, an infrastructure change — since a large fraction of incidents correlate directly with a recent change, and CI/CD and IaC pipeline history is usually the fastest place to look before diving into logs. Third, pull the actual signal — dashboards, error rates, recent logs — rather than guessing from memory of what's usually wrong, because 'usually wrong' is exactly the kind of assumption that wastes the first ten minutes of a genuinely novel incident. And I'd communicate status early and often, even a simple 'investigating, will update in 10 minutes,' because silence during an incident is its own separate problem for everyone waiting on you, independent of how the technical investigation is going.

☐ Can an S3 bucket be renamed? What about an RDS instance?

q075

No — S3 bucket names live in a single global namespace across all of AWS, not per-account, and there's no rename API; the only path is create a new bucket with the new name, copy every object over (`aws s3 sync` or S3 Batch Operations for very large buckets), update every reference to the bucket name across your application and IaC, then delete the old bucket once nothing points at it anymore. RDS instances, by contrast, genuinely *can* be renamed — `aws rds modify-db-instance --new-db-instance-identifier` — but there's an important nuance: renaming changes the instance's endpoint (its DNS hostname), and the operation itself triggers a reboot, so it's not something to do casually against a live production database without a planned maintenance window and every connection string updated in advance to point at the new endpoint.

☐ A colleague asks: 'the DB queries were fine yesterday, why are they suddenly slow today with no code changes?' How do you investigate?

q076

'No code changes' doesn't mean 'nothing changed' — I'd broaden the search immediately rather than taking that framing at face value. Data volume growth is a common silent cause — a query that was fine against 10,000 rows can degrade sharply once a table crosses a size where an index stops being effective or a full table scan becomes noticeably expensive, with no code change required to trigger that shift. I'd check `pg_stat_activity` for currently blocking or long-running queries, connection pool saturation, whether an autovacuum is running and competing for I/O, and whether a query plan has silently changed — Postgres' query planner makes cost-based decisions that can flip as table statistics drift, so `EXPLAIN ANALYZE` on the actual slow query, comparing against what the plan looked like when it was fast, is usually where the real answer surfaces. I'd also check infrastructure-level changes even if 'the code' didn't change — an instance class change, a storage type change, or a noisy-neighbor situation on shared infrastructure.

An engineer says CloudWatch shows the ALB is healthy, but users are reporting 502 errors. How do you reconcile that?

q077

A 502 from an ALB specifically means the load balancer received an invalid or no response from the target it forwarded the request to — so 'ALB healthy' (meaning its own health checks are passing) and '502s happening' aren't actually contradictory; health checks typically hit a lightweight, specific endpoint like `/health`, which can pass even while the *actual* request path the user hit is failing for a different reason. I'd check target group health in detail, not just the ALB's own status, and look at whether targets are being cycled in and out — deregistering during a deploy without enough connection-draining time is a classic cause, since in-flight requests to a target that's mid-deregistration get dropped. I'd also check the target's own application logs for the specific failing request, since the ALB's 502 tells you *that* the backend failed to respond correctly, not *why* — that answer lives in the target's own logs, not the load balancer's.

A GitHub Actions deployment succeeded, but the new version never actually appeared in production. What would you check?

q078

First, whether the deployment actually targeted the right environment — a surprisingly common cause is the default-namespace CI trap in Kubernetes specifically: a `kubectl apply` or `helm upgrade` run without an explicit `--namespace` flag silently applies to whatever namespace the CI runner's kubeconfig context defaults to, which may not be the production namespace the team assumes it targeted — so the deploy genuinely succeeded, just against the wrong place. Second, I'd check whether the image tag actually changed between the old and new deployment — if CI built and pushed a new image but the Deployment manifest still references an unchanged tag (or worse, `:latest` with `imagePullPolicy` not forcing a fresh pull on already-cached nodes), the rollout can report success while functionally running the same old container. Third, I'd confirm the rollout actually completed and isn't stuck mid-rollout — `kubectl rollout status` — since a stuck rollout with `maxUnavailable`/`maxSurge` constraints can leave a mix of old and new pods running long enough that users are randomly hitting either version depending on which pod they land on.

How do you approach a Kubernetes pod that's in `CrashLoopBackOff`?

q079

`kubectl logs <pod> --previous` first, specifically the `--previous` flag, since the current container instance may not have logged anything useful yet — the *previous* crashed instance's logs are usually where the actual error lives. If logs are empty or unhelpful, `kubectl describe pod` for the exit code and any relevant events — exit code 1 is a generic application error, 137 specifically means the container was killed, most commonly via OOMKill if it hit its memory limit, which redirects the whole investigation toward memory usage and limits rather than application logic. I'd also check whether this is a genuinely new failure or a restart-loop triggered by a bad readiness/liveness probe configuration causing Kubernetes to kill an otherwise-healthy container prematurely — that's a meaningfully different fix (adjusting probe timing/thresholds) than an actual application bug, and conflating the two wastes time debugging application code that was never the real problem.

Users report the application is slow but no single error is showing up anywhere. How do you find the bottleneck without a smoking-gun error message? q080

Absence of errors doesn't mean absence of a problem — this is a latency investigation, not an error investigation, and needs different tooling. I'd start with the golden signals broken down per-component along the request path (load balancer, application, database, any downstream service) rather than treating 'the application' as one opaque black box, since latency almost always concentrates in one specific hop, and RED-style p99 latency per component usually reveals which one it is even with zero actual errors present. If it's genuinely diffuse rather than one clear hop, I'd check for resource saturation using USE — is something at or near its ceiling (CPU throttling on a tightly-limited container is a very common, invisible-until-you-check cause of latency with zero errors, since throttling doesn't fail requests, it just slows them down) — and I'd correlate the slowness's start time against recent deploys or infrastructure changes even absent an explicit error, since a subtly worse-performing change can ship clean through CI and only show up as gradual latency degradation in production.

Core Traits & Work Style

SELF-LEARNING, MENTAL MODELS & DOCUMENTATION

This JD explicitly wants 'Self-Learning Autonomy' — comfort reading official AWS docs and interpreting unfamiliar setups without handholding. Give a real example of when you did this. q081

When I needed to design chaos-engineering and recovery automation as part of the RSAB engagement — which drove the 45% recovery-time improvement and eliminated 3 single points of failure — there wasn't an internal playbook to follow for that specific environment's failure modes. I worked directly from AWS's own documentation and Well-Architected Framework reliability pillar guidance to design failure-injection scenarios appropriate to that specific architecture, rather than copying a generic chaos-engineering template that might not match the actual topology and dependencies I was looking at. The instinct I'd point to as the actual skill here isn't just 'I can read documentation' — it's knowing *when* to trust official docs for how a service genuinely behaves versus when I need to go verify against the actual running system, because documentation occasionally lags behind real service behavior, especially on newer AWS features, and conflating the two is how you build automation around an assumption that's quietly wrong.

The JD wants 'System Comprehension & Mental Models' — the ability to build an accurate mental model rather than blindly following commands. What does that look like in practice for you? q082

Before I run any command that changes state, I want to be able to answer 'what does this actually do, and why does it fix what I think is broken' — not just 'I found this command in a runbook and it worked last time.' Concretely, that means before restarting a service, I want to understand *why* it's in the state it's in — is this a transient blip, or a symptom of a resource leak that a restart just papers over temporarily — because those need genuinely different follow-up actions, and blindly restarting on autopilot means the same incident recurs in six hours. It also means, when inheriting unfamiliar infrastructure, deliberately building the dependency graph in my head — what actually talks to what, what's the blast radius of touching this specific resource — before making changes, rather than making an isolated fix and hoping nothing else depended on the thing I just changed. That habit is exactly what let me diagnose the 3 single points of failure at RSAB — it required actually understanding the system's dependency structure, not just reacting to individual alerts as they fired.

Tell me about a time you had to interpret an unfamiliar infrastructure setup with no documentation and no one available to ask. q083

This is a 'bring your own' prompt — I'd want to walk through a real, specific instance from my own engagements (Barclays, Terawe/Synapse, Unique Vacations, or RSAB) rather than a generic answer, and the structure I'd use to tell it: what the environment was, what made it unfamiliar or undocumented, the specific steps I took to build understanding — reading actual resource configurations rather than trusting stale docs, checking CloudTrail or change history to reconstruct *why* something was set up the way it was, testing hypotheses safely in a non-production copy where possible — and the concrete outcome. The RSAB single-points-of-failure work is a strong candidate to anchor this in, since identifying those specifically required reverse-engineering an existing, imperfectly-documented architecture rather than working from a clean specification.

How do you decide when to rely on official documentation versus a quick tutorial or Stack Overflow answer? q084

Production-facing decisions — anything touching IAM policy design, data durability, or a security boundary — I go straight to official AWS documentation and, where it exists, the specific service's Well-Architected best-practices guide, because a tutorial's author usually optimized for 'get this working for a demo,' not for the security and reliability properties that actually matter once something's carrying real traffic and real data. A quick tutorial or forum answer is genuinely useful for the opposite case — a fast, low-stakes syntax question, like 'what's the exact flag name for this CLI option' — where getting it wrong just means a quick retry, not a production incident. The pattern I actively watch for and try to avoid in myself: tutorial code that's clearly copy-pasted into a real system without anyone actually understanding *why* it works, since that's exactly the kind of fragile foundation that breaks in a confusing way later, at the worst possible time, with nobody able to explain why it was built that way in the first place.

How do you approach asking a 'thoughtful, context-aware question,' as this JD's Intelligent Problem-Solving bullet puts it, rather than just asking someone to solve the problem for you? q085

Before asking anyone anything, I make sure I can state clearly: what I'm trying to accomplish, what I've already tried, what I observed when I tried it, and specifically where my own understanding breaks down. That framing does two things — it often surfaces the answer to me on its own partway through writing it out, and when it doesn't, it means whoever I'm asking gets a genuinely answerable, specific question instead of 'this doesn't work, help,' which just pushes the entire diagnostic burden of a problem I've already partially investigated back onto them. I think of it as a basic respect-for-other-people's-time discipline as much as a technical one — a well-formed question is itself evidence that I've actually engaged with the problem rather than looking for a shortcut around doing that work.

A discrepancy shows up during setup or configuration — something small doesn't quite match what you expected. How do you approach reasoning through it rather than dismissing it? q086

Small discrepancies are disproportionately valuable signal, and I've learned not to dismiss them just because they don't obviously seem to be causing a visible problem yet. My approach: first confirm the discrepancy is real and reproducible, not a one-off observation artifact — check it again, ideally a different way. Then reason backward from it: what would have to be true for this specific mismatch to exist — is it a stale cache, a config drift between what's declared in IaC and what's actually deployed, a race condition, or a genuinely wrong assumption I was carrying in. I try to resist the urge to just work around a discrepancy and move on, because in my experience the ones that get waved off as 'weird but not blocking' are disproportionately the same ones that resurface later as an actual incident, at a worse time, once the underlying cause has had longer to compound.

Tricky Questions for This Stack

STACK-SPECIFIC GOTCHAS

- [ ] **If you set `sensitive = true` on a Terraform variable holding a database password, is the password safe?** q087

  No — it's redacted from CLI output only, not encrypted in the state file. If the state backend itself isn't encrypted, the plaintext password is sitting right there in state. The real fix is encrypting the backend and, ideally, sourcing the value from Secrets Manager at apply-time via a data source, or using write-only/ephemeral arguments on Terraform 1.10+ so the value is never persisted to state at all.

- [ ] **Can you rename an IAM role after it's created?** q088

  No, IAM roles can't be renamed — you have to create a new one with the desired name, copy its trust and permission policies, repoint every reference to it, then delete the old one. IAM users and groups, notably, *can* be renamed directly.

- [ ] **If a CloudFormation stack update fails and rollback also fails, what state is the stack in, and what do you do?** q089

  It lands in `UPDATE_ROLLBACK_FAILED`. You identify the specific resource CloudFormation can't reconcile — often something manually modified outside the stack — and use `continue-update-rollback`, sometimes explicitly skipping that one resource, then reconcile it by hand afterward.

- [ ] **A ConfigMap referenced by a Deployment gets updated. Do the pods automatically pick up the change?** q090

  No — Kubernetes has no built-in 'restart on ConfigMap change' mechanism. Pods keep running with whatever they already loaded unless the application itself is actively watching the mounted file, or you force a rollout — commonly via a checksum annotation on the pod template that changes whenever the ConfigMap content changes.

- [ ] **Your Kubernetes Deployment shows `no endpoints` for its Service even though matching pods exist and are Running. What's the most likely cause?** q091

  The pods are Running but not passing their readiness probe — a Service only routes to Ready pods, not merely Running ones. Second most likely: a label selector mismatch between the Service and the pods, often from a typo introduced during a refactor.

- [ ] **Someone `docker exec`'d into a running container and changed a config file, then restarted the container. Is the change still there?** q092

  Yes — `docker restart` preserves the container's writable layer; it doesn't reset the container to the image's pristine state. Only removing the container and running a fresh one from the image discards that layer. If the change needs to survive a real redeploy, it has to go into the image or an external config source, not a live `exec` edit.

What does exit code 137 on a Kubernetes pod usually mean, and what's your first check?

q093

137 is 128+9, signal 9 (SIGKILL) — most commonly an OOMKill when the container exceeded its memory limit. First check is `kubectl describe pod` for the OOMKilled reason and `kubectl top pod` history against the configured memory limit, not the application logs first, since the process was killed externally rather than crashing on its own.

A CI pipeline shows green but the app is broken in production. Where do you look first?

q094

The gap between what CI tests and what production actually exercises — usually a mocked-out downstream dependency, or an environment-specific config difference CI never sees. Green doesn't mean 'no bugs,' it means 'no failures in what we chose to test' — those are different claims.

What's wrong with deploying an image tagged `:latest` to production?

q095

`:latest` isn't a guarantee of anything specific — it's just a mutable pointer that gets reassigned on every push, so two pods started at different times, or a node that pulls a fresher `:latest` than what's already running elsewhere, can end up running genuinely different code under an identical-looking tag. Immutable, unique tags — a git SHA or semver — are the only way 'what's deployed right now' is actually answerable and reliably rollback-able.

Leadership & Behavioral

STAR / SAROB EXAMPLES

☐ Tell me about a time you significantly improved system reliability. Walk me through it using a structured example. q096

Situation: at RSAB IT India, the environment had accumulated single points of failure that nobody had systematically mapped or tested against real failure scenarios. Action: I designed and ran chaos-engineering exercises to deliberately surface where the architecture would actually break under failure, rather than relying on assumptions about what was resilient. Result: identified and eliminated 3 concrete single points of failure, and drove a 45% improvement in recovery time for the incidents that chaos testing surfaced. I'd emphasize the methodology as much as the number in an interview — the value wasn't the testing itself, it was building a repeatable process for *finding* the failure modes nobody had thought to test for, which is a transferable practice, not a one-off fix.

☐ Describe a situation where you had to reduce noise or improve signal in a monitoring/alerting setup. q097

At Terawe, working on the Azure Synapse Analytics platform for a Microsoft client, alert volume had grown to the point where the team's trust in alerts was degrading — which is the real danger of alert fatigue, not just the annoyance of extra notifications. I audited existing alert rules for ones firing on transient conditions rather than sustained problems, added proper duration windows so alerts required a condition to persist before firing, and consolidated related low-signal alerts into fewer, more meaningful composite ones. That drove a 40% reduction in alert noise, and — just as importantly for an interview answer — it rebuilt the team's actual trust that when something did page, it was worth immediately taking seriously, which is the outcome that actually matters operationally, not the percentage on its own.

☐ Tell me about a time you caught a problem before it caused an outage. q098

At Terawe, this ties to the same Synapse platform engagement — as part of tightening observability there, I also improved detection speed for genuine issues, contributing to a 35% reduction in mean-time-to-detect. I'd walk through a specific detection improvement in the actual interview — what the previous detection gap looked like concretely, what change closed it, and a specific instance where the improved detection caught something before it escalated — rather than just citing the aggregate percentage, since a specific example is what actually demonstrates the underlying judgment to an interviewer, not the number by itself.

☐ How do you approach mentoring a junior engineer who's struggling with a production issue, without just solving it for them? q099

I'd walk through my general framework here, and pair it with a real example if I have one specific enough to share honestly. The framework: ask what they've already tried and observed before offering anything, since that surfaces exactly where their mental model is breaking down rather than me guessing. Then guide with questions rather than answers where possible — 'what does that error actually tell you,' 'what would you expect to see in the logs if that were true' — so they're building the diagnostic muscle themselves, not just receiving a fix they'll need again from me next time. I'd only step in and directly solve it once a live production issue is actually time-critical enough that teaching-by-questions is the wrong call in that specific moment — knowing which mode the situation calls for is itself part of the judgment.

Tell me about a disagreement you had with a teammate or lead about a technical approach, and how it resolved.

q100

This is a 'bring your own' prompt — I'd want to anchor it in a specific, real disagreement rather than a generic conflict-resolution answer. The structure I'd use: what the two approaches actually were and why each had a real case behind it (not a strawman on one side), how I made my case — ideally with data or a concrete trade-off analysis rather than just asserting a preference — how the decision actually got made, and what happened afterward, including if my position turned out to be wrong, since a genuine answer to this question usually isn't 'I was right and they came around' every single time, and interviewers generally read that too-clean version as evasive.

How do you track and communicate progress on a long-running infrastructure initiative to non-technical stakeholders?

q101

I translate technical milestones into business-relevant terms rather than status-reporting the technical work itself — not 'we migrated 60% of services to the new IaC pattern,' but what that migration actually buys the business: reduced manual-deployment effort (I drove a 60% reduction in one prior engagement), fewer production incidents, faster recovery when something does go wrong. I'd give regular, predictable updates rather than only reporting when something's newsworthy, since stakeholders trust a steady cadence more than sporadic 'good news' updates, and I'd be upfront about slippage or blockers as soon as they're real, not once they've become undeniable — that's consistent with the gap-honesty approach I take generally, since a surprised stakeholder at the end is a worse outcome than an uncomfortable but early conversation about a risk.